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a shutter speed of 1/4-1/2000, which is quite fast for a low-end camera. But here again the camera decides the shutter speed, not the user.

Storage media: The cameras in the market today generally come with 8 MB storage, with exceptions such as the Kodak DC-4800, which comes with a 16 MB compact flash card. Amongst the cameras with resolution lower than 1024x768, only the Kodak EZ200 had 4 MB of built-in memory, while other cameras such as the D-Link's Digi-Link and Intel Pocket camera had built-in 8 MB flash memory.

The Kodak MC3 had an inbuilt MP3 player and 16 MB of compact flash, which is only sufficient for either images or MP3s.

White Balance: Lower-end VGA cameras do not have a manual option for white balance setting. These cameras adjust the setting automatically. While almost all the cameras had the white balance setting, the Fuji

FinePix 2400 had a total of six white balance settings. In the low-end category, the

Kodak mc3 and EZ200 came with an auto white balance, whereas the Intel and D-

Link's Digi-Link didn't have the feature at all. This is bad as a basic function like this is necessary in all digital cameras.

Dimension and weight: These are important criteria for any digital camera as these are portable devices and need to be carried by hand while in use. A bulky camera is difficult to hold for long and could affect the photographs you take to some extent. The camera that outshone the others here was the Canon IXUS, which is just a little bigger than your visiting card and weighs only 190 gms. The Sony's Cybershot DSC-

P1 is very compact as far as dimensions go, weighing only 250 g, and can be carried in your trouser pocket.

Among the low-end cameras D-Link's Digi-Link was the smallest, even smaller than the Canon IXUS and also the lightest, weighing only 110 g. It fits easily in your palm.

LCD Screen: The LCD screen size and quality is very important if a difficult target needs to be shot, and shooting it through the optical viewfinder is not possible.

Cameras such as Sony's DSC-P1, Kodak DC-4800 and Fuji FinePix 2400 had very good, crisp and bright LCD screens. The image is clearly visible in the



Kodak mc3: Good bun-

dled software

Printing your Photograph

If you thought that buying the best camera in the country could ensure you best quality photographs, then you're right. But if you think this also entitles you to high quality printouts on a normal A4 size paper, on your low-end printer, then you're wrong. A high-resolution printout of the photographs that you click on your digital camera would need the best photo printer and glossy paper (the special shiny paper used for printing photographs). There are many photo printers available in the market, which are a shade costlier than a regular colour inkjet printer but are optimised for photo printouts.

Glossy paper in A4 size would cost you around Rs 20 and a colour printout of the photograph at the best resolution the camera has to offer would cost you another Rs 15. The total cost of the photograph will come to around Rs 30-35, which is still more expensive than a regular photograph from a conventional cam-

era. However, here you have an option of printing only the snaps you want which is not the case with a regular roll, where you have to print all 30-35 snaps.

A new technology just released by Epson, called print image matching, lets you connect your camera directly to the printer and get a printout of the photograph, which is as good as a regular photograph, without losing any information. This is the same for any image viewing software, which sets its own print command. Since a digital camera captures the images in wider colour spaces, the printer is unable to access this information as the image files are optimised for limited computer monitor colour space. These restrictions have been overcome by these new printers and, hence, produce images as seen from the camera lens. So if you plan on buying a digital camera, you could spend a little more on a good printer and have a photo-finishing lab of your own.

